

Chapter 158_2 - Ending (Part 2)

After noon had passed, they headed to the last realm that Chu Qingqiu wanted to take Ning Fuyi to.

Penglai Realm.

At this time, Penglai Realm had already restored to its original state, still standing majestically amidst the sea of clouds. Only the waterfall that had once cascaded down was now dry, and the rubble formed by the collapsed mountainside on one side bore witness to the warfare this place had once endured.

When they entered Penglai Realm, they encountered no obstruction. The immortal guards at the entrance recognized them, half-kneeling in salute, but were stopped by Chu Qingqiu.

The interior of Penglai was indeed like a fairyland, with clouds and mist swirling underfoot, immortal pools lining both sides of the path, and several colorful koi swimming in the pools. When their tails lifted droplets of water, they left trails of rainbow silk on the water's surface.

Chu Qingqiu seemed to not be visiting this place for the first time, moving as if she belonged here, while Ning Fuyi was much more silent. She passed through several archways and walked past some pavilions, but only saw a few scattered Penglai people.

"Where are the people of this place?" Ning Fuyi asked in surprise.

"After that battle five years ago, Penglai suffered heavy losses. Both the Emperor and Empress couldn't stay, and the Penglai clan naturally declined. So most of the Penglai people left the immortal mountain - some became wandering cultivators in the mortal world, others joined immortal sects, each finding their own path," Chu Qingqiu answered.

They walked to a cliff area where seven-colored clouds rolled beneath the cliff, and above the cliff they entered what seemed like a dense forest, except this "forest" was composed of numerous tombstones of various sizes scattered across the entire cliff.

At the center of the cliff stood the largest tombstone, painted in a beautiful peach-pink color, with many fresh flowers and offerings placed before it, obviously changed daily.

"Shiqi¹..." Ning Fuyi murmured. She gazed at the tombstone for a long time, then stepped forward and bowed three times.

Then she conjured a bouquet of flowers and placed it separately.

Chu Qingqiu had brought her here to pay respects to Baili Shiqi, Ning Fuyi knew. She stood quietly in the clouds and mist for a while before being taken by the hand by Chu Qingqiu and led out of this forest of tombstones.

She couldn't say much either. When she looked at that tombstone, she didn't feel any intense grief, because she always felt that someday in the future, Baili Shiqi with her braided hair would jump out from the wind, laughing as she asked if she wanted to go roam the martial world together.

Then let it be so.

Holding her beloved's hand, accompanied by old friends, leading an old horse, to roam these vast rivers and mountains anew.

When the two were leaving, they encountered a woman in front of Penglai Hall. The woman wore light blue robes, had soft hair, and unremarkable features, but her eyes were brilliant as stars - once you met her gaze, it was like being immersed in a dream.

The woman looked at Ning Fuyi, but Ning Fuyi didn't recognize this person and politely said, "You are..."

The woman smiled, opened her mouth but made no sound, while words echoed in Ning Fuyi's mind: "Does the Demon Lord not remember me?"

Hearing this voice, Ning Fuyi's eyes widened in shock as she looked the woman up and down: "Yun Ke?"

"You've become a woman?" She stepped forward to take Yun Ke's hand, examining with curiosity those obviously softer hands, causing the woman to laugh bashfully.

"Merfolk live in the depths of the sea - ten years to grow legs, a hundred years to distinguish male and female," she said to Ning Fuyi. "After you destroyed the Mountain and River Map³ with your body, I developed a female form."

"Very good, very good." This was also Ning Fuyi's first time seeing a merperson change gender, and she was about to take a closer look when she suddenly felt a chill creep up her spine.

Then someone inconspicuously pulled her hand back, grasping it in their palm under the bright daylight.

"Left Protector," Chu Qingqiu said coolly to Yun Ke. "Are you tired today?"

Yun Ke's fan-like eyelashes blinked, then she clasped her now-empty hands together, smiled as usual, and made hand gestures: "Thank you for Divine Venerable's concern. Now that Penglai is sparsely populated, it requires little effort."

"That's good then. If there's nothing else, we'll take our leave first." Chu Qingqiu politely nodded to her, then pulled Ning Fuyi toward the exit of Penglai Realm.

Ning Fuyi looked back to see Yun Ke still watching their direction, raising her hand in farewell.

Then her waist was encircled by an arm that forcibly turned her around.

"Watch where you're going," Chu Qingqiu said coldly.

The two stepped onto the return journey, but Chu Qingqiu still maintained a cool expression, not speaking to her the entire way. Ning Fuyi knew she was annoyed, so she lifted her leg to touch the white bone under Chu Qingqiu's feet, reaching from behind to embrace her waist.

She was pushed away.

Ning Fuyi didn't give up and reached out to embrace her again. This time her feet suddenly felt light, and when she opened her eyes again, she had passed through the clouds and was falling from the sky.

Ning Fuyi immediately found this both crying and laughing. She urgently summoned Xiangsi⁴ to step on and looked up to find that white figure, then ascended back up.

"I merely hadn't seen a merperson change gender before and looked a few more times. I had absolutely no other intentions - please don't be angry," Ning Fuyi said, flying beside her and reaching to pull at her sleeve.

"Looking is one thing, but why did you hold her hand?" Chu Qingqiu frowned.

"I didn't hold her hand, I just picked it up to look!" Ning Fuyi randomly grabbed a passing bird from nearby and demonstrated in front of Chu Qingqiu, "Like this, picking it up."

"You think it's acceptable to pick up other women's hands?" Chu Qingqiu's tone became even heavier upon hearing this.

Seeing that she was truly annoyed, Ning Fuyi stopped being playful and released the bird: "Alright, now I know. I won't touch them in the future."

Hearing her promise, Chu Qingqiu's expression softened. After a moment of silence, she said again, "I'm not asking you not to interact with people, it's just that the way she looked at you wasn't right. I saw it and felt concerned."

"Do you think I'm being unreasonable?" Chu Qingqiu lowered her eyes.

Ning Fuyi shook her head so vigorously it made wind sounds. She smiled and said, "Not unreasonable at all - rather adorable. The more you control me, the more delighted I am. I wish I could transform into the clothes on your body so you could control me every day."

"What nonsense are you talking about?" Chu Qingqiu waved her sleeve to pat Ning Fuyi's back, saying in annoyance.

As twilight approached, the two chatted and laughed as they returned to the hillside. Halfway up the slope they could see lights glowing on the hill - bonfires blazing, cooking smoke rising in a line connecting to the sky.

The mellow fragrance of warming wine spread throughout the valley, and even passing birds seemed intoxicated, flying lower than usual.

"Why are the candles in the house still lit? Didn't we extinguish them when we left?" Ning Fuyi asked, looking down. But she quickly realized, slightly retracting her chin as she looked at the pursed-lipped Chu Qingqiu.

"You spread the news about my recovered memories?" she asked in surprise.

"They were also very worried about you," Chu Qingqiu said.

Hearing this, Ning Fuyi's smile spread from the corners of her eyes: "I suppose that's true."

Like any ordinary day, she led Chu Qingqiu home. Jiuying⁵ stood by the bonfire holding freshly roasted chicken, fragrant as she gnawed on bones while waving at them.

"You called us here, yet you two played around and didn't come home. Even the wine had to be bought by me - how cunning!" Jiuying glared at her with phoenix eyes, then pulled her to her side and handed her a cup of peach blossom wine⁶. "First, a penalty cup."

"The monthly allowance I give you is quite generous. Just buying two jugs of wine couldn't possibly bankrupt you, could it?" Ning Fuyi smiled mischievously as she bantered with her, turning to circle around her hand. "Where are the others?"

"Doctor Jiang and Han Ya⁷ and the others are inside wrapping zongzi⁸. Liu Wenzhu and Hua Feihua went to town, saying they wanted to buy more vegetables and meat to make hot pot⁹ to go with wine." Jiuying glared at her and withdrew the wine cup. "If you won't drink, then don't."

She turned and resumed gnawing on the roasted chicken. Having been in the Demon Realm for so long without human world delicacies, she was now so delighted by the fragrance that she swayed her waist. Ning Fuyi warned her to be careful not to let her qilin¹⁰ tail show, then smiled as she took Chu Qingqiu's hand and walked into the house filled with bright candles.

"That's not how you wrap zongzi! Do you actually know how or not!" Han Ya was arguing with Xi Que¹¹ about something, chattering noisily. When she saw Chu Qingqiu's figure, she immediately threw rice all over the floor and bounced toward her.

However, perhaps seeing Ning Fuyi's warning glare, she stopped just half an inch away, looked at Chu Qingqiu nearby, and laughed cheerfully, "Demon Lord!"

"Divine Venerable, Yiyi¹², come quickly!" Jiang Li¹³ stood up from the table with a gentle smile, pulling the two to the table side as she softly muttered, "These two little demons are too clumsy. They've been at it for half an hour and haven't managed to make a single zongzi."

"These delicate tasks still require Divine Venerable. Divine Venerable can even embroider rabbits, let alone mere zongzi wrapping." Ning Fuyi smiled as she took the green bamboo leaves, teasingly saying.

The words had barely left her mouth when she received a knock on the back of her head. Then she saw Chu Qingqiu walk to the table, coldly take the rice ladle, and wordlessly begin scooping yellow rice.

The outcome could naturally be anticipated. Chu Qingqiu's skills were no better than Han Ya and the others' - either the rice leaked out or the leaves tore. After wrapping more than ten, none looked presentable. In the end, Ning Fuyi had to take over the task and work with Jiang Li to finish wrapping the remaining zongzi.

After the zongzi went into the pot, the sky had already darkened. While waiting for the zongzi to cook, Ning Fuyi took Chu Qingqiu's hand and, staying away from the smoke and fire, walked toward the cloud-like flowers blooming down the hillside.

Ning Fuyi asked, "How has Doctor Jiang been these past five years?"

"As usual," Chu Qingqiu said softly. "Hei Lin¹⁴ disappeared again after that day and hasn't shown her face since. I don't know where she went."

"Most people in the world are like this - they walk together for a while, and when fate is exhausted, they part ways," Chu Qingqiu sighed.

"We will never part," Ning Fuyi suddenly said, gripping Chu Qingqiu's hand firmly, ignoring the fine sweat in her palm.

Even when there was still that curse to worry about, she wasn't afraid. Now that the evil spirit was dead and the curse had disappeared, there was even less that could stand in their way.

She loved Chu Qingqiu. This love could withstand all obstacles and endure the passage of long years.

Chu Qingqiu looked at her eyes in the shadow and couldn't help but smile, raising her hand to ruffle her hair: "Alright."

The laughter from above tore through the night and reached her ears. Ning Fuyi suddenly sat on the ground, then pulled Chu Qingqiu over, indicating for her to lie down.

Chu Qingqiu obediently pillowed her head on Ning Fuyi's lap. As her body turned, the vast sky appeared in her vision - the brilliant stars like an unrolled scroll, with the sky hanging down on all sides to the mountains, vast and serene.

After the two were quiet for a while, Ning Fuyi suddenly remembered something and asked, "If I had harbored feelings for you from the beginning, then when did you start harboring feelings for me?"

This question obviously stumped Chu Qingqiu. She stared at the sky, pondering for a long time before honestly opening her mouth: "Perhaps... from the beginning¹⁵."

"Really?" Ning Fuyi looked down with a smile. "But you were extremely cold at that time."

"Some things are difficult for a person to perceive themselves," Chu Qingqiu smiled. "Do you still remember when you accidentally entered my memory at Zhaoyao Mountain¹⁶ and saw that flower forest?"

Ning Fuyi nodded: "I remember. I even vaguely suspected later why in your memory we were deeply in love, but I didn't remember it."

Chu Qingqiu paused, then said, "Because that was my dream."

Ning Fuyi was speechless. She opened her mouth but said nothing, yet her heart became increasingly elated - so elated she couldn't help but want to harmonize with the insect songs in the mountains.

So even back then, she had already developed feelings for her.

"Yiyi," Chu Qingqiu suddenly looked at her. "I like you so much."

She didn't know when it started, but she had become helplessly infatuated. In the past, she thought those stories in romance novels about climbing mountains of knives and descending into seas of fire, about living to return and dying for eternal longing, were all foolish talk from mortals. But now she felt:

Oh, it's nothing more than that.

Ning Fuyi could no longer contain her smile. Just as she was about to lower her head to kiss her, she heard Jiuying's loud shout from above: "Ning Fuyi! Divine Venerable! Come back to eat!"

"I'm not very hungry. What about you?" Ning Fuyi asked.

Chu Qingqiu winked at her, and then Ning Fuyi pulled Chu Qingqiu up. The two ran through the sea of flowers toward the riverside, their laughter chasing after them, dampening the corners of their clothes as it disappeared into the summer night.

The bright moon shone eternal, startling a flock of gulls beneath its light.

————End of Main Text————

Footnotes:

1. **Shiqi (拾七):** Baili Shiqi's name, meaning "Seventeen"
2. **Yun Ke (云客):** A merperson character, literally "Cloud Guest"
3. **Mountain and River Map (山河图):** A powerful magical artifact
4. **Xiangsi (相思):** The name of Ning Fuyi's sword, meaning "Yearning/Lovesickness"
5. **Jiuying (九婴):** A character whose name means "Nine Infants," a type of mythical creature
6. **Peach blossom wine (桃花酿):** A traditional Chinese alcoholic beverage
7. **Han Ya (寒鸦):** A character whose name means "Cold Crow"
8. **Zongzi (粽子):** Traditional Chinese rice dumplings wrapped in bamboo leaves
9. **Hot pot (古董羹):** A traditional Chinese cooking method, literally "antique soup"
10. **Qilin (麒麟):** A mythical Chinese creature, often translated as "unicorn"
11. **Xi Que (喜鹊):** A character whose name means "Magpie"
12. **Yiyi (衣衣):** An affectionate nickname for Ning Fuyi
13. **Jiang Li (江离):** The Divine Doctor character
14. **Hei Lin (黑鳞):** A character whose name means "Black Scales"
15. **From the beginning (混沌):** Literally "chaos," referring to the very beginning of time/creation
16. **Zhaoyao Mountain (招摇山):** A location name meaning "Beckoning Mountain"